Helping students access and use digital course resources

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D14 S1–S6

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Check that students can reach and use required resources before substantial learning or assessment depends on them. Access problems, unfamiliar tools, English instructions and inaccessible formats require different responses. Do not assume that frequent phone use means familiarity with academic tools.

1. Check access before requiring a resource

Ask students to test a required resource early using the devices and accounts available to them.

- Check device compatibility, account permissions and connection requirements.
- Provide a private route to report difficulties.
- Arrange campus access or an appropriate alternative with relevant support staff.

Example Engineering — Before a simulation task, ask students to open a practice activity. Arrange a supported campus session or an equivalent activity if their device cannot run it.

2. Make resources easy to locate

Use a predictable course location and descriptive names. Explain what students need from each resource.

- Group related materials by topic or week and distinguish essential resources.
- Check links and permissions using the platform's student view where available.

Example Business — Under "Week 4 preparation", link the case, data file and preparation questions with a short description of each.

Use the institution's approved course systems where possible. When linking elsewhere, explain any additional sign-in or software requirement before students begin.

3. Demonstrate the required steps

Show the actual task with the relevant tool and provide a short reference students can revisit.

- Model the steps, explaining your actions.
- Provide numbered instructions and labelled screenshots where useful.
- Give a small practice task before assessed or substantial use.

Example Economics — Demonstrate opening the dataset, selecting variables and producing a graph. Students create a practice graph and check its labels and values.

4. Explain digital instructions and terms

Identify interface words students must understand and show the controls they refer to. Use the wording displayed in the actual system.

- Explain the difference between saving, uploading and submitting in this platform.
- Ask students to check the completion status or confirmation rather than assuming the action succeeded.

Example Public health — "Attaching the file uploads it. In this system, you must also select Submit. Check the confirmation and open the submitted file to verify it is the intended version." Adapt instructions to the platform and device. Do not assume that a control has the same name or location on a phone and a computer.

5. Provide accessible formats and alternatives

Make essential information available in formats students can read, navigate and use.

- Use selectable text and document headings; provide text alternatives for meaningful images.
- Provide accurate captions and, where useful, an illustrated text explanation for video.
- Offer workable downloads or lower-bandwidth alternatives where possible.

Example Environmental science — Alongside a process video, provide captions and a text explanation with labelled images containing the information needed for the task.

6. Explain troubleshooting and support routes

Give students a short first-response guide and identify who handles technical problems and subject questions.

- Point to the current institutional help service and opening hours.
- Ask for the resource name, device, time and error message; avoid sharing passwords or access codes.
- Explain what to do when an access problem affects a deadline, using published assessment procedures.

Example Nursing — "If the case will not open, note the error and contact technical support. Tell me promptly if preparation is affected. For assessment deadlines, follow the published reporting process."

Digital task guide template

Field	Complete for your course
Resource and purpose	Name, direct link and what students will do.
Access and practice	Required account or device; practice task and completion check.
Steps and key terms	Numbered actions and explanations of essential controls.
Alternative or support	Approved alternative; technical help and course contact.
If a deadline is affected	Link to the current assessment process.

Complete and check all fields before sharing. Use a redacted screenshot if reporting an error would otherwise reveal personal information.

A short routine to try

Test access, demonstrate the process, explain key controls and let students practise. Check completion, offer accessible alternatives and keep support information easy to find.

7. Supporting Sources

SUNY Online. (n.d.-a). *OSCQR – Standard #8*.
SUNY Online. (n.d.-b). *OSCQR – Standard #12*.
SUNY Online. (n.d.-c). *OSCQR – Standard #16*.
University of California, Davis. (n.d.). *Create an inclusive class climate online*.
University of Michigan, LSA Technology Services. (2020). *Accessible courses, online and hybrid edition*.